The Problem

By A.R. Gurney, Jr.

INTRODUCTION

Actress:	A pipe-smoking absent-minded Professor hasn't had marital relations with his beautiful young wife for five years, but doesn't seem to notice she is pregnant. He nobly deigns to accept the child as his own.
Actor:	And that's just he beginning of . . . The Problem by A.R. Gurney, Jr.

WIFE: Hey.

HUSBAND: (Not looking at her.) I'm reading, dear.

WIFE: (Sticking out her stomach.) I know. But look at me.

HUSBAND: (Still reading.) I'm preparing for a class, dear.

WIFE: I know, but just look. (She crosses to him, stands by his chair, and sticks out her stomach.) Just take a gander. (HUSBAND turns his head and looks right into her stomach. He starts, takes off his glasses, looks again, and then looks up into her face.) Well, well.

WIFE: Yes.

HUSBAND: Surprise, surprise. Why have I never noticed before?

WIFE: Because I wear loose-fitting clothes.

HUSBAND: That's true.

WIFE: Clothes without waists. Merri-mekkos. Sack dresses. Granny gowns.

HUSBAND: That's true. (Pause. They smile at each other. Then he looks at his watch.) I've got to teach a class in an hour.

WIFE: I just wanted you to know. (Pause.) So you could plan.

HUSBAND: Yes. I will. I'll plan accordingly. (Smiles at her again, puts on his glasses, and returns to his book. She starts off left, and then stops.)

WIFE: Oh, there's one thing, though.

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HUSBAND: (Reading.) Mmmmmm?

WIFE: One small problem.

HUSBAND: (Reading.) Mmmmmm. And what's that, dear?

WIFE: I don't know whether you've thought about this, or not.

HUSBAND: (Looking up.) State the problem. And I'll tell you whether I've thought about it.

WIFE: It's a little tricky.

HUSBAND: Well. We're married, after all.

WIFE: All right. (Pause.) You see, I'm not absolutely sure that this. . .(She looks down at her stomach.) is yours. (Pause. He marks his place in his book, puts it down carefully, takes off his glasses, and then looks up.)

HUSBAND: Ah. So that's the problem.

WIFE: Yes. That's the problem.

WIFE: The thing is . . . that you and I . . . haven't made love very much. Recently. Well, I mean. . . five years, more or less. . . give or take a month or two.

HUSBAND: (Lighting his pipe.) My gosh, has it been that long?

WIFE: Oh, yes.

HUSBAND: Yes, yes. I understand now. What you're really saying is . . .now stop me if I'm wrong. . . but what you're really saying is that you think someone else might have impregnated you.

WIFE: More or less. Yes. On these evenings that you have to go teach.

USBAND: So we do have a problem there, don't we?

WIFE: Yes. We really do. (Pause; he looks at her, looks at her stomach, scratches his head, taps his teeth with a pencil, lights his PiPe, twirls his glasses.)

HUSBAND: You know, darling. . . it occurs to me . . . that I should have made love to you more. But why didn't I? Darn it! Darn it all!

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WIFE: Darling, you have your work.

HUSBAND: Oh, sure, but. . .

WIFE: You have your intellectual life . . .You had your book to get out. . .

HUSBAND: Yes, yes, but, darling, that doesn't really answer the question. The question is, why haven't I made love to you in the past five years? That's the question. (Pause.)

WIFE: Well. You used to laugh too much, maybe.

HUSBAND: Laugh?

WIFE: Yes. In the old days. Whenever we started to make love, you'd start to chuckle.

HUSBAND: I did, didn't I? I remember now. (He chuckles.)

WIFE: Yes. You'd chuckle.

HUSBAND: (Chuckling.) Because the whole thing struck me as being slightly absurd. (Chuckling.) When you think about it. (Chuckling.) I should learn to control myself. (He chuckles louder; controls himself stoically; then bursts into loud laughter; then forces himself to subside; looks at her.) I'm sorry.

WIFE: Oh, don't be sorry. I was just as bad.

HUSBAND: Did you chuckle?

WIFE: No. Actually I'd cry.

HUSBAND: I don't remember your crying.

WIFE: Well, I'd whimper.

HUSBAND: Yes, yes! You would. You'd whimper. (Chuckles.)

WIFE: Well, I felt so sad! Making love. While all these horrible things are going on in the world.

HUSBAND: Yes. So you'd whimper. I remember now.

WIFE: Vietnam... Urban blight. . . all that. . . . I felt so guilty!

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HUSBAND: And I felt so absurd.

WIFE: Yes. You chuckling, me whimpering. . . .

HUSBAND: Yes. Oh, yes.

WIFE: And so it wasn't very conducive.

HUSBAND: Right. So we gave it up. That answers that. (Pause; picks up his book and starts to read.)

WIFE: But now there's this. (Indicates her stomach.)

HUSBAND: Keep it. Bear it. Bring it home. Give it my name. Consider me its father.

WIFE: Oh, sweetheart.

HUSBAND: I've let you down. Now I'll make it up. Keep it. But you're not satisfied.

WIFE: Oh, I am, I am.

HUSBAND: Darling, we've been married ten years. You are not satisfied.

WIFE: You've got a class.

HUSBAND: My wife comes first. Come on. What's the problem now?

WIFE: All right. (Pause.) What if this. . . (She looks at her stomach.) turns out to be black? (Pause.)

HUSBAND: Black?

WIFE: Black. Or at least mulatto. Depending on how the chromosomes line up. I mean, can you still act as its father if it's black?

HUSBAND: (Pause. Settles down.) Black, eh? That's a problem. (Pause.) So you must let me think it out.

WIFE: But your class. . .

HUSBAND: I'll just be less prepared than I like to be. Which may be good. Which may be very good. Which may make things more lively and spontaneous. So let me think about this other problem. (Puffs on his pipe; she stands watching him.) I could still adopt it.

WIFE: How?

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HUSBAND: We could tell the world that you had a blue baby. Which died. And then we could bring home the black one. Which we say we adopted.

WIFE: That sounds awfully complicated. Besides, the real father might object. He might take pride in it himself.

HUSBAND: No, no. Now wait a minute. . . . (He thinks carefully, then suddenly pounds his fist on the arm of his chair.) Sweetheart, I'm going to be honest with you. (Points to the footstool.) Sit down. Now don't look at me. Face forward. Because this is going to be hard for me to tell, and hard for you to hear.

WIFE: All right. I won't look at you.

HUSBAND: And if I'm inarticulate about this, you must try to understand that this is a difficult thing for a man to tell his wife. I'm only doing it-I'm only telling you-because it seems to be the only way to solve this problem. All right. (He takes a deep breath.) Now. To begin with, I've been lying to you this evening. I don't have a class tonight. I've never had a class at night. I don't believe in evening classes. All these years I've been lying. The class that I've told you meets at night actually meets on Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays at ten A.M.

WIFE: I see.

HUSBAND: You may well ask, therefore, where I go on these nights when I say I have classes. (Pause.) And that is what is so difficult to tell you. (Pause.) The fact is, I don't leave this house. Not really. Oh, I leave by the front door, all right. But I immediately circle around in back and go down into the cellar by means of the bulkhead. Now. What do I do in the cellar? You are probably asking yourself that. What do I do in the cellar? . . . Don't look at me, darling! (Pause; then grimly:) Here's what I do in the cellar. I make my way to a small space behind the furnace. And in that

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small space, I have hidden. . . certain things. (Pause.) What have I hidden? I'll tell you. (He counts them off on his fingers.) Some black theatrical makeup. A woolly wig. A complete change of clothes. And a small mirror. That's what I have hidden in the cellar.

WIFE: I see. . . .

HUSBAND: Yes. You see, my darling, or you're beginning to. When I go into the cellar, I set the mirror up on an adjacent water pipe. I strip myself to the buff. I daub myself from head to toe with that dusky makeup. I glue on that curly wig. I don those makeshift clothes. I leave the cellar. Go to the front door. Ring the bell. And reappear to you. So you see, my poor darling, I am your Negro visitor, and have been all along.

WIFE: You.

HUSBAND: Oh, I know it sounds implausible. But remember how you always lower the lights. Remember, too, that I played Othello in high school. Somehow I was able to pass. I have deceived you for these past years. Deceived my own wife! Disguising myself as a Negro and capitalizing on the sympathies you naturally feel for that unhappy race!

WIFE: But... why?

HUSBAND: Because I wanted to make love to you. And somehow this seemed to be the only way I could do it. You'll have to admit it worked.

WIFE: (Looking at her stomach.) Oh, yes. It worked.

HUSBAND: SO out of all this depravity, at least a child will be born. And I was its father, after all.

WIFE: I'm somewhat. . . stunned. . . by all this. (Grimly.) Sit down. I have a tale to tell too. . . I've known all along you were my dark lover!

HUSBAND: (Sits down.) You've known?

WIFE: From the beginning.

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HUSBAND: But... how?

WIFE: Five years ago, when you announced to me that you had scheduled some evening classes, I became suspicious. And so when you left for the first class, I . . . followed you. Yes. I followed my own husband. Followed you to that tacky little theater-supply shop downtown where you bought your disguise. Followed you into the cellar, hid behind the hot-water heater, watched you change into your poor, pathetic imitation of a Negro. When I understood that you were doing it for me, my heart went out to you. With a great rush of longing, I dashed back upstairs, eager to receive you, but at the same time terrified that you would see that I recognized you. Frantically, I dimmed the lights, to make things easier for both of us.

HUSBAND: I thought it was because you were romantic.You were acting? The whole time?

WIFE: Yes. Wasn't I good? Pretending that you were someone new and strange? I, I, who am no actress, improvising like a professional during that whole scene!

HUSBAND: (Shaking his head.) It's hard to believe. . . . You seemed so . . . excited!

WIFE: I was! I was terribly excited. I'll admit it. That strange, sly courtship, the banter, the give-and-take, with all those peculiar racial overtones. I threw myself into it with a vengeance. . . . This is hard to say, but looking at you now, slouched in that chair, surrounded by your books and papers, I suddenly have the strange urge to experience the stale comforts of bourgeois married love. But there's still this! (Indicating her stomach.) This problem!

HUSBAND: (Moving toward her.) That's no problem.

WIFE: No problem?

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HUSBAND: (Stalking her.) That's not really a baby you have in there.

WIFE: (Backing away.) Not really a baby?

HUSBAND: No. That's a balloon you have in there.

WIFE: A balloon? It's a baby. I'm practically positive.

HUSBAND: No, no. Look. I'll show you. (Takes the pointed metal prong of his pipe cleaner and gives her a quick, neat jab in the stomach.) Touche! (There is a pop, and then a hissing sound. She slowly deflates. They both watch.) You see? The problem was simply academic. (Pause.)

WIFE: (Looking at him sheePishly.) Aren't we awful?

HUSBAND: (Going to his chair, closing his book, carefully marking the place.) You started it.

WIFE: I know. It was my turn. You started the last one.

HUSBAND: (Neatening his books and papers.) Well, it's fun.

WIFE: Shouldn't we see a psychiatrist?

HUSBAND: (Tapping out his pipe; putting his glasses in his glasses case.) Why? We're happy. (Turns off his light. The stage is now lit only from a light off left.)

WIFE: But we're so depraved! (He looks at her, then throws back his head and gives a long Tarzan-like whoop; then he pounds his chest like a gorilla; she giggles.) Quiet! You'll wake the children! (He picks her up in his arms; she pummels him melodramatically; speaks in an English accent.) No, Tarzan! White men do not take women by force! No, Tarzan! White men court their women!

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AWARD HISTORY

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